

## Vaccinating India: On zero-dose children

The **prevalence** of zero-dose children **remains** high among the poor

On the bright side, **vaccine coverage** globally, between 1980 and 2023, **doubled** for six diseases including measles, polio and tuberculosis. Also, at 75% globally, there has been a sharp fall in the number of **zero-dose children** — those who have not received the first dose of the diphtheria, tetanus, and pertussis (DTP) vaccine — during the same time period. The **number** of zero-dose children **is** a crucial performance **marker** and an indicator of vaccination coverage **inequities**. Despite increased **immunisation** coverage over the **decades**, in 2023, at 1.44 million, **India**, according to The Lancet, still **had** the second largest number of zero-dose children, and **is** among the eight countries with over 50% of the nearly 16 million zero-dose children globally. Most of the zero-dose children globally are in countries that are **conflict-affected** or with limited resources for vaccination programmes — India has neither of the two problems. However, about 23 million babies were born in 2023 in India, the highest in the world; in 2024, China, which has the second highest number of newborns globally, reported just 9.5 million newborns. Though the number of zero-dose children is **staggering**, when seen in the **context** of the number of newborns in 2023, the **percentage** of zero-dose children in India **is** 6.2%. A study in 2021 found that India had sharply reduced the percentage of zero-dose children, from 33.4% in 1992 to 10.1% in 2016. Before the COVID-19 **pandemic**, the **number** of zero-dose children **was** 1.4 million in 2019 but this **swelled** to 2.7 million in 2021 and then dropped to 1.1 million in 2022 before increasing to 1.44 million in 2023.

As in the 2021 study, **a large percentage** of zero-dose children **are** in Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Maharashtra, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, and Gujarat. There is also a relatively high proportion of them in Meghalaya, Nagaland, Mizoram and Arunachal Pradesh. Over the years, the **difference** in zero-dose children based on gender, caste, and rural-urban status **has** reduced **substantially**. However, prevalence remains high among the poor, mothers with low education, Scheduled Tribes and Muslims. Focus is needed to **immunise** children in **hard-to-reach** tribal areas, **urban slums** where there is a huge **migrant** population, and in reducing **vaccine hesitancy** among Muslim households with newborn children. India has much work to do to **meet** WHO's Immunization **Agenda 2030** (IA2030) — halving zero-dose children **relative** to 2019. With the number of zero-dose children in 2023 (1.44 million) only about nearly reaching the 2019 level of 1.4 million, India needs greater and **sustained** efforts to **halve** this number in the next five years. **[Practice Exercise]**

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

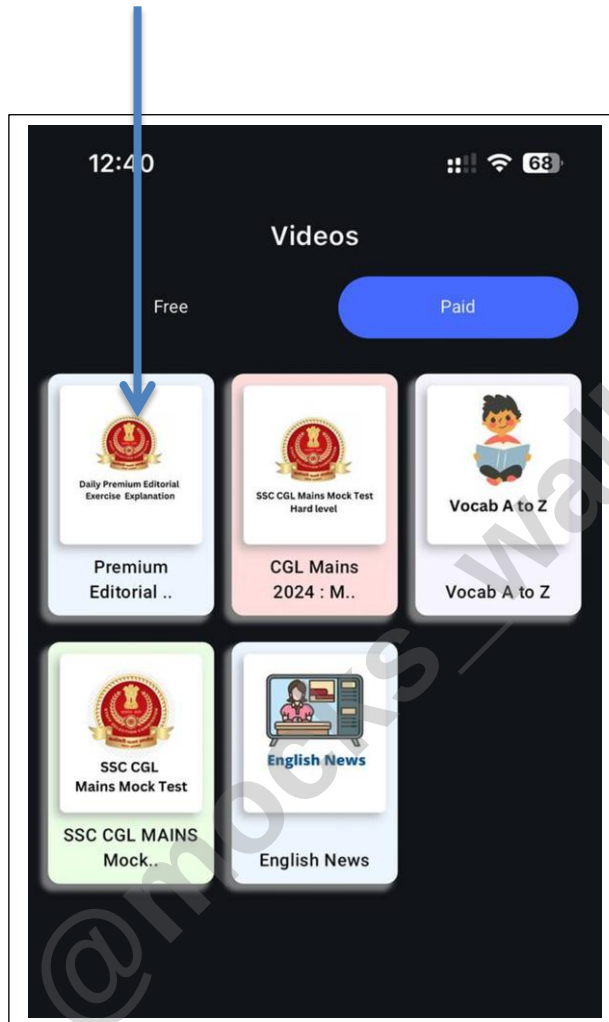
## Vocabulary

1. **Vaccinate** (verb) – Immunize, inoculate, inject, protect, safeguard टीका लगाना
2. **Zero-dose children** (noun) – those children who have not received even a single vaccine shot.
3. **Prevalence** (noun) – Frequency, occurrence, pervasiveness, commonness, dominance 'प्रचलन'
4. **On the bright side** (phrase) – Positively, fortunately, optimistically, looking at benefits, from a hopeful perspective सकारात्मक दृष्टिकोण से
5. **Marker** (noun) – Indicator, sign, signal, measure, symbol संकेतक
6. **Inequity** (noun) – Inequality, injustice, disparity, unfairness, bias असमानता
7. **Immunization** (noun) – Vaccination, inoculation, protection, immunizing process, disease prevention टीकाकरण
8. **Decade** (noun) – Period of Ten years, दशक
9. **Conflict-affected** (adjective) – War-torn, strife-ridden, violence-hit, crisis-stricken, unrest-affected संघर्षग्रस्त
10. **Staggering** (adjective) – Astonishing, overwhelming, shocking, immense, mind-blowing चौंकाने वाला
11. **Context** (noun) – Circumstance, background, situation, framework, setting संदर्भ
12. **Pandemic** (noun) – Global outbreak, epidemic, worldwide disease, contagion, widespread illness महामारी
13. **Swell** (verb) – Increase, rise, surge, expand, escalate बढ़ना
14. **Substantially** (adverb) – Significantly, considerably, greatly, markedly, meaningfully काफी हद तक
15. **Immunise** (verb) – Vaccinate, protect, inoculate, safeguard, shield टीका लगाना
16. **Hard-to-reach** (adjective) – Inaccessible, remote, isolated, difficult-to-access, outlying दुर्गम
17. **Urban slum** (noun) – densely populated, impoverished areas within cities, characterized by substandard housing, poor sanitation, and limited access to basic services like clean water and healthcare शहरी झुग्गी
18. **Migrant** (adjective) – Mobile, itinerant, traveling, moving, transient प्रवासी
19. **Vaccine hesitancy** (noun) – reluctance or refusal to have oneself or one's children vaccinated against an infectious disease or diseases.

20. **Meet** (verb) – Achieve, fulfill, accomplish, satisfy, attain पूरा करना
21. **Agenda** (noun) – Plan, program, schedule, list of goals, strategy कार्यक्रम
22. **Relative** (to) (adjective) – Compared with, in relation to, proportional to, as against, respective के सापेक्ष
23. **Sustained** (adjective) – Continuous, prolonged, steady, ongoing, persistent निरंतर
24. **Halve** (verb) – Reduce by half, split, cut down, divide, decrease आधा करना

@mocks\_wallah

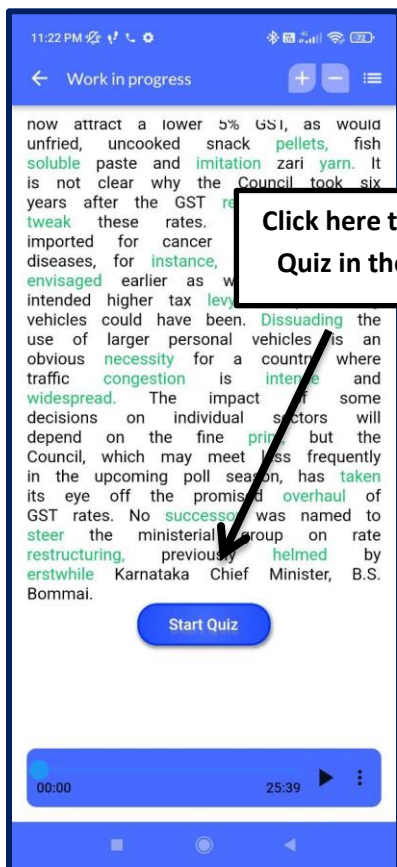
**Video solution of Practice Exercise from this Editorial is exclusively available on App.**



## Summary of the Editorial

1. **Global vaccine progress:** Vaccine coverage for six diseases like measles, polio, and tuberculosis has doubled globally between 1980 and 2023.
2. **Zero-dose children defined:** Zero-dose children are those who have not received the first dose of the DTP (diphtheria, tetanus, pertussis) vaccine, a key indicator of immunisation equity.
3. **Global reduction:** The global percentage of zero-dose children has dropped sharply, reaching 75% coverage.
4. **India's ranking:** In 2023, India had 1.44 million zero-dose children — the second highest number in the world.
5. **Global concentration:** India is among eight countries accounting for over half of the world's nearly 16 million zero-dose children.
6. **No conflict barrier:** Unlike many countries with high zero-dose numbers, India does not suffer from conflict or severe resource shortages for vaccination.
7. **High birth rate context:** India saw 23 million newborns in 2023, the highest globally, compared to China's 9.5 million.
8. **Proportion context:** Despite the absolute number being high, zero-dose children made up 6.2% of India's 2023 newborns.
9. **Historical progress:** From 1992 to 2016, India reduced its percentage of zero-dose children from 33.4% to 10.1%.
10. **Pandemic setback:** Zero-dose numbers rose from 1.4 million in 2019 to 2.7 million in 2021 due to COVID-19 disruptions.
11. **Recent fluctuations:** After the peak in 2021, the number fell to 1.1 million in 2022 but rose again to 1.44 million in 2023.
12. **Regional concentration:** States like Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Maharashtra, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, and Gujarat have the highest absolute numbers of zero-dose children.
13. **Northeast challenges:** Meghalaya, Nagaland, Mizoram, and Arunachal Pradesh also have high proportions of zero-dose children.
14. **Equity improvement:** Differences in zero-dose prevalence by gender, caste, and rural-urban location have reduced substantially over the years.
15. **Persistent inequities:** High prevalence persists among the poor, mothers with low education, Scheduled Tribes, and Muslims, requiring targeted strategies, especially in tribal areas, urban slums, and addressing vaccine hesitancy.

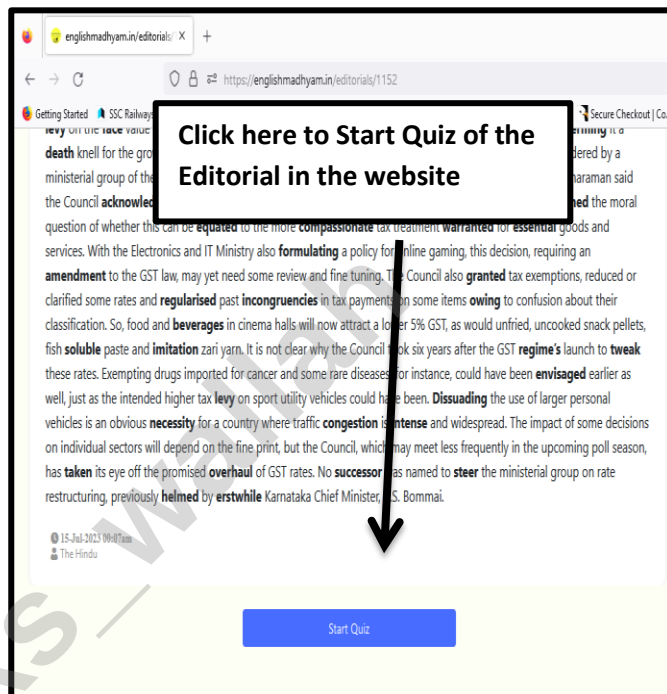
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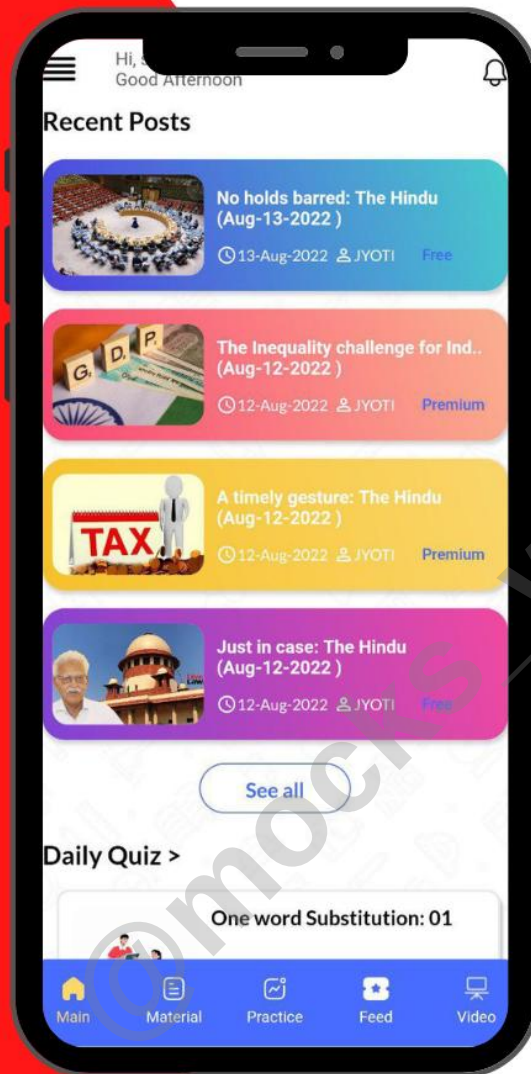
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